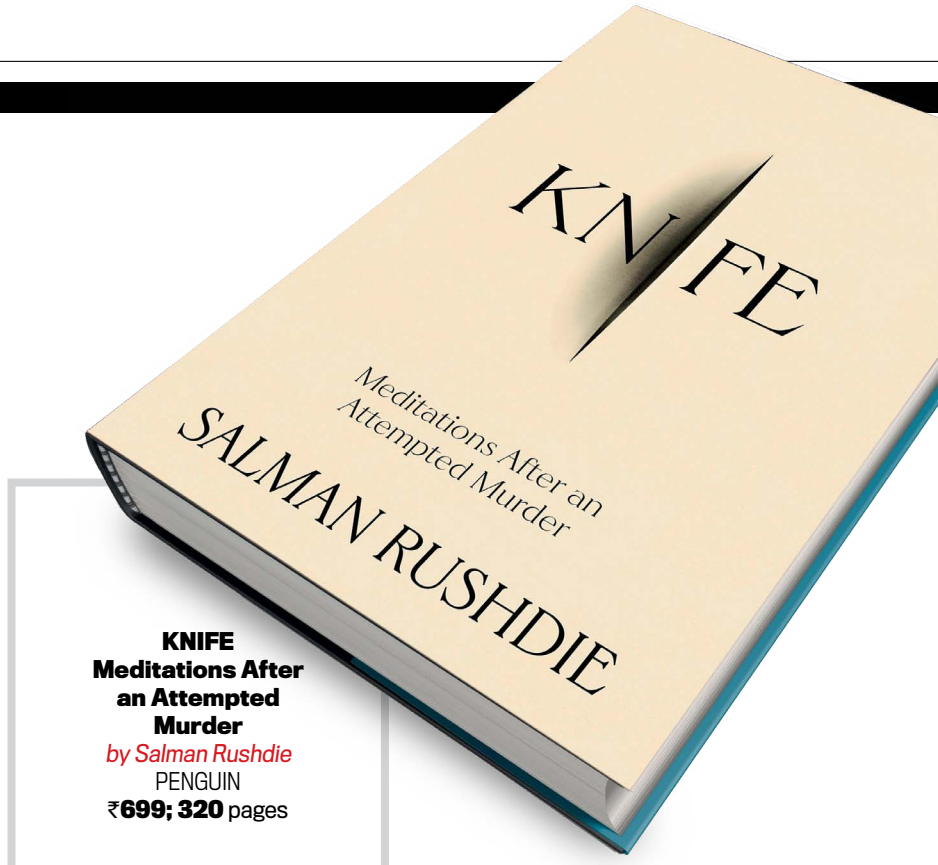


KNIFE
Meditations After an Attempted Murder
by Salman Rushdie
PENGUIN
₹699; 320 pages

Being a novelist has never been a particularly dangerous occupation, especially compared to serving on a bomb squad, test piloting fighter jets or climbing mountains in the Himalaya. Nevertheless, it does entail certain risks, especially when religious fanatics decide that your stories are heretical and blasphemous. As most readers know, Salman Rushdie has spent more than three decades living under the shadow of a fatwa issued by Ayatollah Khomeini on account of his novel, *The Satanic Verses*. For the first ten years after that death threat was issued, Rushdie had to go into hiding, protected by British police.

Eventually emerging from the isolation and constant fear of a violent attack, he moved from London to New York and became a US citizen. Defying the fatal injunction against him, Rushdie wrote and published another twelve novels, as well as two collections of essays and a memoir, *Joseph Anton*, in which he recounts the experience of living under the ever-present threat of assassination. With the support of family, friends, and fellow writers, he gradually regained his freedom and became a public figure once again. But then, on August 12, 2022, after he stepped on stage at the Chautauqua Institution in upstate New York to give a talk about the persecution of authors and their need for protection and asylum, a masked man raced up the aisle and attacked him with a knife, stabbing Rushdie fifteen times. The life-threatening injuries he received included the loss of his right eye, deep wounds in his neck and torso, as well as severe damage to his left hand.

Knife: Meditations After an Attempted Murder begins with an account of the attack, though most of the book describes the heroic and desperate efforts to save Rushdie's life, as well as the slow and painful struggle to regain physical and mental well-being. Surprisingly, this book is also a love story in which he recounts the deeply personal and intimate bond between him and his wife, Rachel Eliza Griffiths. A poet, artist, photographer and musician, she supports and sustains Rushdie throughout the ordeal and gives him hope and happiness in the face of trauma and despair.

In many ways, *Knife* is the medical equivalent of a police procedural, in which the primary focus is the victim's body, detailing the wounds inflicted and the healing process. The attacker's identity is not a mystery, though Rushdie refuses to name him, simply referring to him as "the A" or "the Ass". Hundreds of witnesses in the audience at Chautauqua observed the attack, though the would-be murderer pleaded "not guilty." One chapter of the book shifts into fiction, when Rushdie imagines himself interviewing his assailant, comparing their conversation to interrogations in the TV show *Law & Order*. *Knife* contains many references to popular culture, including Twitter, the Doonesbury comic strip and online gaming. Rushdie's clever wordplay is evident throughout, and he includes an array of literary references from Voltaire's *Candide* to John Berryman's *The Dream Songs*.

THE COMPELLING CLARITY OF RUSHDIE'S PROSE IN THIS BOOK OFFERS AN ELOQUENT REPUDIATION OF HIS ENEMIES AND HARSHEST CRITICS